

History & Folklore Water-resistant, alder was used in the construction of Venice. Wooster Beech (1794–1868), founder of the Eclectic healing movement, used a decoction of the bark to “purify the blood.”

Medicinal Actions & Uses Alder is most often used as a mouthwash and gargle for tooth, gum, and throat problems. The drying action of a decoction of the bark helps to contract the mucous membranes and reduce inflammation. A decoction may also be used to staunch internal or external bleeding, and to heal wounds. It is also used as a wash for scabies. In Spain, alder leaves are smoothed and placed on the soles of the feet to relieve aching. Leaves are used to help reduce breast engorgement in nursing mothers.

Alstonia spp. (Apocynaceae) Fever Bark

Description Evergreen trees growing to 49 ft (15 m). Have glossy oblong leaves and creamy-white, star-shaped flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation *A. constricta* is native to Australia, and *A. scholaris* to Australia and Southeast Asia. Both are now found in tropical regions around the world.

Parts Used Stem bark, root bark.

Constituents The bark of both species contains indole alkaloids. *A. constricta* contains reserpine, a powerful hypotensive.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Fever bark has been taken to treat malarial fever (and has been called Australian quinine), but its efficacy against malaria remains unclear. The bark is antispasmodic and lowers blood pressure, and is now used mainly to reduce high blood pressure. Strongly bitter; the bark is also taken to treat diarrhea.

❗ **Cautions** Take only under professional supervision. Fever bark is toxic in large doses. The herb is subject to legal restrictions in some countries.

Althaea officinalis (Malvaceae) Marshmallow

Description Downy perennial growing to 7 ft (2.2 m). Has thick white roots, heart-shaped leaves, and pink flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to Europe, marshmallow is naturalized in the Americas. It prefers marshy fields and tidal zones and is cultivated for medicinal use. The aerial parts are gathered in summer as the plant begins to flower and the root is unearthed in autumn.

Parts Used Root, leaves, flowers.

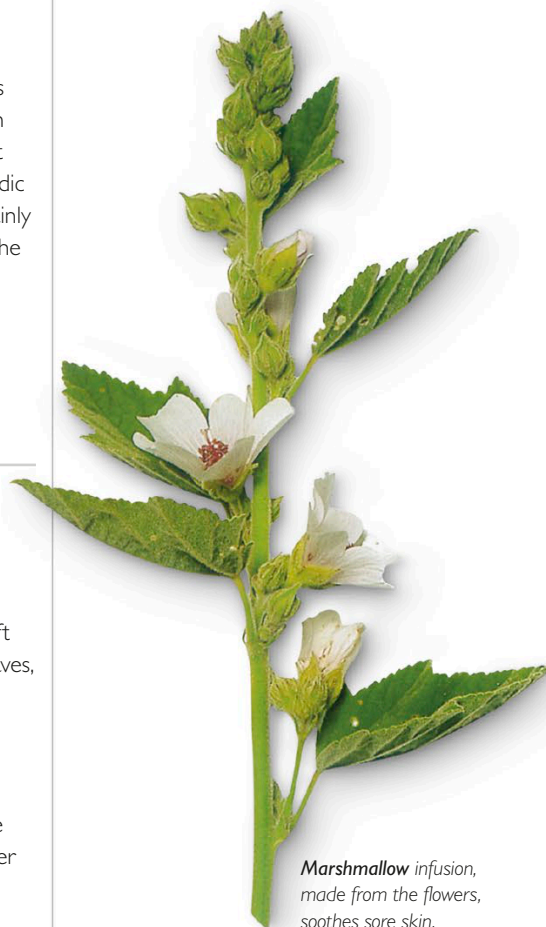
Constituents Marshmallow root contains about 37% starch, 11% mucilage, 11% pectin, flavonoids, phenolic acids, sucrose, and asparagine.

History & Folklore The philosopher Theophrastus (c. 372–286 BCE) reported that marshmallow root was taken in sweet wine for coughs. Marshmallow was once a key ingredient in the sweets of the same name.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Useful whenever a soothing effect is needed, marshmallow protects and soothes the mucous membranes. The root counters excess stomach acid, peptic ulceration, and gastritis. Marshmallow is also mildly laxative and beneficial for many intestinal problems, including regional ileitis, colitis, diverticulitis, and irritable bowel syndrome. The leaves treat cystitis and frequent urination. Marshmallow's demulcent qualities bring relief to dry coughs, bronchial asthma, chronic bronchitis, and pleurisy. The flowers are applied to help soothe inflamed skin. The root is used in an ointment for boils and abscesses, and in a mouthwash for inflammation. The peeled root may be given as a chewstick to teething babies.

Other Species Hollyhock (*A. rosea*) and common mallow (*Malva sylvestris*, p. 232) are used in a similar fashion.

Self-help Uses Allergic rhinitis with mucus, p. 300; Earache due to chronic mucus, p. 312; Urinary infections, p. 314.



Marshmallow infusion, made from the flowers, soothes sore skin.

Amaranthus hypochondriacus (Amaranthaceae) Amaranth

Description Sturdy, upright annual growing to about 3 ft (1 m). Has deeply veined, lance-shaped, purple-green leaves that grow to 6 in (15 cm) and tufts of small, deep crimson flowers on long spikes.



Amaranth's long-lasting flowers gave rise to its name, meaning “unwithering” in Greek.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to India, amaranth grows wild in many countries, including the U.S. A common garden plant, it is harvested when in flower in late summer and early autumn.

Parts Used Aerial parts.

Constituents Amaranth contains tannins, including a red pigment used to dye foods and medicines.

History & Folklore Amaranth comes from the Greek word meaning “unwithering.” The amaranth was sacred to the goddess Artemis, worshipped at Ephesus, and was thought to have special healing powers. As a symbol of immortality, it was used to decorate tombs and images of the gods.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Amaranth is an astringent herb that is used primarily to reduce blood loss and to treat diarrhea. A decoction of amaranth is taken as a remedy in cases of heavy menstrual bleeding, excessive vaginal discharge, diarrhea, and dysentery. It is also used as a gargle to soothe inflammation of the pharynx and to hasten the healing of canker sores.

Related Species Quinoa (*A. caudatus*, also known as Inca wheat) is a nutritious Andean grain. It is used to make bread and is eaten in salads. The seeds of *A. grandiflorus* are used as a foodstuff by Australian Aborigines.